propped up in his pyjamas, ‘fretting himself half-mad at everything going wrong’, he sent repeated messages urging the commanders to move into, not out of, Shuja’s ancient fortress. ‘Were Sturt’s advice taken, we should nightly send ammunition there,’ recorded Lady Sale in her diary, ‘and, when a sufficiency is conveyed, all make one bold night march in very light marching order, just what we can carry on our horses. In there we can be lodged (not comfortably, I grant) in the houses of the inhabitants. They have laid in their stores for the winter, which would be bought at any price, and then we might defy all Afghanistan for any time.’[65] But the reply to Sturt’s plan from the commanders was: ‘How can we abandon the cantonments when they have cost us so much money?’

After the departure of Shelton, Shuja was left alone in his fortress with what was left of the Shah’s Contingent and the handful of British officers attached to it. According to Lady Sale:

> [he] took up his abode at the gate of the harem sarai, where he remained during the rest of the siege; and all day, seated at the window, commanding a fine view of the Cantonments, telescope in hand, watched anxiously the course of passing events in that place, sunk into a state of despondency. He put off for a time all the insignia of royalty, made the officers sit by him on chairs, and seemed for a time quite *gobrowed*, an expressive Eastern term to be rendered something between dumbfounded and at one’s wits’ end.[66]

By the second week of November, with British positions in the Bala Hisar, the city and all the forts around the cantonment now lost or abandoned, the fighting began to centre instead around Bibi Mahru, which had become the last source of supplies for the increasingly desperate British. Here a series of inconclusive engagements took place around the forts dominating the village and overlooking the cantonment. On 10 November, the insurgents tightened the noose around the British by occupying the heights on either side and, ‘more numerous than ants or locusts’, seized a tower house on the crest of one hill directly opposite called the Rikab Bashee’s fort.[67]

Three days later, the rebels manhandled two captured field guns on to these heights. As before, Shelton declined to take action, citing the risks of defeat. ‘Brigadier,’ said an exasperated Macnaghten eventually, ‘if you will allow yourself to be bearded by the enemy, and will not advance and take these two guns by this evening, you must be prepared for any disgrace that may befall us.’[68] The following morning at dawn Shelton finally made a